

Augmented Analytics in SAP Analytics Cloud:

A Study of Impact and User Adoption

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Abstract

While enterprises advance from conventional business intelligence towards the development of AI-powered ecosystems, one of the challenges associated with AI lies in its promises of "automated insights." In this paper, we attempt to analyze the influence and adoption rate of Augmented Analytics in SAP Analytics Cloud (SAC). Moving beyond benchmark analysis of the SAC technology's effectiveness, we explore how its features such as Smart Insights and Natural Language Querying help make the decision process more efficient. Using a combination of research methods, we evaluate the "trust gap" that exists between automatically generated stories and human intuition. According to our results, although SAC's augmented capabilities allow reducing the amount of time used for the pre-processing stage by a significant margin, the adoption rate will be determined not only by the level of technological advancement but also by the notion of a "cognitive partnership" perceived by users.

Keywords: *Augmented Analytics, SAP Analytics Cloud, Smart Discovery, Time-to-Insight, Trust Gap, Explainable AI, Data Governance, Business Intelligence, SAP S/4HANA, Mixed Methods*

1. Introduction

With the evolution of digital business models, data has become the key driver of business growth rather than a supplementary element. The challenge that organizations encounter in their digital transformation journeys is the emergence of a new "volume paradigm," which implies generating data in huge amounts and having issues with translating it into valuable insights that could be used in making decisions. Conventional BI solutions, built in an era when companies had manageable volumes of information and relied on experts for its analysis, are not sufficient anymore to meet present-day requirements.

According to Statista, the augmented analytics market globally, which reached a value of USD 15.5 billion in 2024, is expected to grow and amount to USD 80.4 billion by 2033. Augmented Analytics represents a blend of artificial intelligence and machine learning algorithms with conventional BI. Contrary to the older system, Augmented Analytics utilizes natural language processing and generation technologies to enable automation of data preparation and pattern discovery processes. This approach is referred to as "democratization of data" and allows end users without technical expertise to manage massive volumes of information with minimum human effort.

SAP Analytics Cloud (SAC), meanwhile, has become a significant part of this revolution through the incorporation of elements such as Smart Discovery, Smart Predict, and Joule, an artificial intelligence-powered generator. Thanks to the incorporation of these features, SAC seems able to offer a streamlined progression from insight to action. It should be noted, though, that the implementation of such tools poses not only a technical issue but also one of a different sort, according to Gartner. This can be seen in terms of factors like distrust, poor data quality, and the "black box" element of AI models.

2. Literature Review

2.1 Evolution of Business Intelligence and the Emergence of Augmented Analytics

The field of Business Intelligence (BI) has witnessed tremendous transformation. Traditionally, BI was based on structured reporting and dashboarding, which were appropriate for low volumes of enterprise data and decisions that did not require swift action. However, due to increased enterprise data resulting from digital transformation and cloud computing, traditional BI was unable to handle the requirements of contemporary business. Augmented analytics, which integrates BI with AI technologies, has been identified as one of the most important analytics tools today, capable of converting enterprise data into actionable intelligence efficiently. Gartner officially coined the term "augmented analytics" in 2017.

2.2 Core Technologies Underpinning Augmented Analytics

Augmented analytics relies on ML, NLP, and NLG technologies. Unlike BI that processes small amounts of data, augmented analytics leverages these AI technologies to analyze large amounts of data, establish relationships, and generate valuable insights through automation of the entire process, including data cleansing, evaluation, visualization, and even development of ML models. Through NLP, non-technical users can ask questions using plain language without the need for data professionals. Using NLG, analytical results can be explained using plain language.

2.3 Augmented Analytics in SAP Analytics Cloud

In SAP Analytics Cloud (SAC), augmented analytics is maturely incorporated within an enterprise environment with AI-powered functionality such as Smart Discovery, Smart Insights, Smart Predict, and Search to Insight, integrated in planning and BI. The use of augmented analytics automates processes which would otherwise demand significant manual effort and advanced data science skills to complete by utilizing features of augmented analytics. "Just Ask" and "Search to Insight," amongst other tools, make it easy to develop AI-driven visualizations from natural language questions and detect pertinent columns in data without any user intervention. SAP aims to incorporate generative AI into SAC's main workflows with the help of an AI assistant named Joule for quick, safer business decisions.

2.4 Impact on Organizational Decision-Making and Efficiency

Numerous studies have proven that the application of augmented analytics has an overwhelmingly positive impact on organizational efficiency. For instance, the application of augmented BI in Romanian organizations yielded faster and more accurate reports, saved time,

developed better strategies, provided better customer services, and brought in extra income, and was deemed essential for competitive advantage by top executives. The results of ThoughtSpot research demonstrate that decision-making accuracy can be improved by 20 to 30 percent through AI-powered predictive analytics. Additionally, according to Gartner's prediction, by 2025, 75 percent of all analytics usage will be automated data storytelling generated by augmented analytics. A systematic review conducted from 2013 to 2023 proves that augmented analytics had a great impact on business efficiency, competitive advantage, and stakeholder interactions.

2.5 User Adoption and the Technology Acceptance Model (TAM)

Although technical capabilities are analyzed for augmented analytics technologies, there is a need to examine aspects of behavior and organization for user adoption. The primary theory underlying user acceptance of technology is the Technology Acceptance Model (TAM) proposed by Fred Davis (1989). It assumes that characteristics of the system determine the level of adoption through ease of use and perceived usefulness, the two primary determinants of user attitudes and intention to adopt. For artificial intelligence, TAM is adapted to consider trust and quality of output. User trust and output quality have been found to enhance intention, usefulness, and ease of use in AI-based systems.

2.6 The Trust Gap in AI-Assisted Analytics

It is evident from the literature that there is a "trust gap" because the users have reservations about relying completely on the AI algorithms for the analysis, despite the superior performance of the former compared to the latter. It is relevant in the corporate context since there are severe ramifications attached to the decisions made. According to Gartner, the absence of organizational trust, low-quality data, and regulatory ambiguity are some of the key obstacles to AI implementation. The data cannot be trusted, thereby affecting the process of decision-making. As AI analytical systems operate like "black boxes," it is difficult to comprehend the decision-making process.

2.7 Data Quality and Governance as Enablers of Augmented Analytics

Indeed, several studies have pointed out the importance of data quality as the single-most important factor in ensuring that the promises of augmented analytics are fulfilled. Issues such as data inconsistency, inaccuracies, incompleteness, and poor governance may make it difficult for businesses to trust AI generated insights. This means that data literacy challenges may make it impossible for business professionals to make sense of the findings obtained through automated analysis.

It therefore means that technology alone cannot guarantee the successful deployment of augmented analytics. Businesses require both technological capabilities as well as complementary data capabilities in order to make use of automated insights.

2.8 Research Gaps

Although there have been many academic studies related to augmented analytics in recent years, many literature gaps still exist in that realm. For instance, most studies focus on augmented

analytics at a general level rather than examining its implications for use within particular enterprise environments such as SAP Analytics Cloud (SAC). The relationship between user trust, data governance, and platform-oriented design characteristics with regards to SAC implementation has not been comprehensively studied in the literature. In addition, although generative AI was recently introduced into SAC, there has been very little empirical analysis about its effects on users' behaviors.

3. Methodology

3.1 Research Design

This study adopts a mixed methods research design that involves both quantitative and qualitative elements for a holistic evaluation of the effects of augmented analytics technology in SAP Analytics Cloud and the variables affecting adoption. This mixed method not only quantitatively assesses the performance outcomes but also qualitatively explores the behavior. The research employs the explanatory sequential strategy where quantitative data is obtained first followed by the collection and analysis of qualitative data. The conclusions arrived at from the analysis of quantitative data will be further explored through qualitative inquiries, such as the link between efficiency improvement and user trust.

3.2 Research Objectives and Questions

These are the guiding research questions of the study:

RQ1: In what way does the use of augmented analytics functionalities in SAP Analytics Cloud save time compared to manual data modeling approaches?

RQ2: How well do the insights produced using AI in SAC tools such as Smart Discovery and Smart Insights match the reality of business in corporate databases?

RQ3: What is the main determiner, such as trust, user-friendliness, data quality, and organizational readiness, of the adoption of augmented analytics capabilities in SAP Analytics Cloud?

RQ4: What is the perception of functional consultants and business analysts in relation to the validity of forecasts created through SAC's forecasting module?

3.3 Research Population and Sampling

Purposive sampling technique was employed whereby samples were selected based on their extensive practical experience with the SAP Analytics Cloud (SAC) platform together with augmented analytics tools, namely; Smart Discovery, Smart Insights, Search to Insight, and Smart Predict. A pragmatic sample size of 50 - 70 participants was chosen so as to generate rich insight from the interviews. Samples were collected through SAP consulting firms, SAC

implementation teams, LinkedIn communities, and the SAP Community network. Qualifying criteria included a minimum of 6 months of hands-on experience with SAC and at least one augmented analytics tool.

3.4 Data Collection Instruments

Data was collected through two primary instruments:

3.4.1 Structured Survey Questionnaire

Questionnaire design was carried out systematically, with digital distribution to the intended sample. It was divided into the following five parts based on themes:

- **Part A:** Demographics (SAP expertise, job level, business sector, SAC maturity scale).
- **Part B:** Augmented analytics utilization patterns (frequency, purpose).
- **Part C:** Numerical evaluations (1 to 5) of time-to-insights, accuracy of results generated by AI, and comparison of automated versus manual insight detection.
- **Part D:** Confidence in findings produced by artificial intelligence, intention to follow AI advice, and factors that drive adoption (Technology Acceptance Model (TAM): perceived benefits, simplicity), along with specific considerations related to AI reliability and transparency.
- **Part E:** Qualitative feedback on issues encountered during SAC analysis using augmented analytics, potential areas for enhancement, and user satisfaction.

Prior to implementation, pilot testing was conducted with a limited sample of five SAP users to fine-tune the wording of questions and avoid ambiguity.

3.4.2 Comparative Performance Analysis

Meanwhile, there was also a comparative analysis carried out using SAC's enhanced analytics and the conventional method of manual data modeling. The two systems were tested using the same enterprise procurement data set, performing similar tasks such as data profiling, outlier discovery, trend recognition, and prediction. Evaluation criteria included:

- Time consumed to perform the analytical tasks
- Insights generated
- Outlier and anomaly detection accuracy
- Quality of predictions

The comparative analysis enabled an objective and task-based evaluation of the actual efficiency improvement made possible by SAC's AI functionalities.

3.5 Data Analysis Techniques

The analysis of quantitative Likert-scale data involved the use of descriptive statistics such as means, standard deviations, and frequencies to study the tendency and variance. The analysis of inferential statistics focused on the relationship between variables (such as the relationship between data quality/trust, and experience/technology adoption readiness). The coding process used in analyzing qualitative data was done by looking for repeated themes. Cross-comparison of qualitative themes and quantitative findings was done for credibility purposes. Comparative performances were compiled and measured against benchmarks; improvements in percentages were computed per indicator.

3.6 Validity and Reliability

For enhancing the validity of the research tool, the research survey is supported by existing theories such as Technology Acceptance Model (Davis, 1989) and various elements from literature on augmented analytics adoption. The content validity of the questionnaire was determined by conducting an expert review whereas its construct validity was confirmed with the help of piloting and further improvement of the questionnaire.

To determine the reliability of the study, the researchers made sure that scales consisting of more than one item were used to measure important constructs. For checking the internal consistency, the researchers used Cronbach's Alpha where a score of at least 0.70 was needed to consider the reliability of scales.

3.7 Ethical Considerations

Voluntary responses were obtained from all participants in the research, and participants were apprised of the aims of the research before filling out the questionnaire. Confidentiality was ensured during both the data gathering and reporting stages, where no identification details were provided or collected. Information obtained from organizations for comparative analysis purposes was either fictitious or used with the necessary clearance.

3.8 Limitations

Despite the mixed-methods strength, limitations exist. Self-reported data risks response bias, especially concerning AI accuracy and trust. Purposive sampling limits statistical generalizability to the wider SAP user population. Varying organizational factors, like data governance and training, influenced user experiences. Triangulation and performance data partially address these, also indicating future research directions.

4. Implementation

4.1 Overview of the Implementation Framework

Inaugurating the use of augmented analytics in SAP Analytics Cloud (SAC) involves a series of activities such as data preparation, configuring, enabling users, and adopting the technology gradually. SAP Analytics Cloud combines analytics and planning into one cloud solution, which offers fast insight-to-action capabilities, scenario simulations, and automatic predictive planning based on data predictions for quick decision making. This sub-section presents the implementation of SAC's augmented analytics functionalities in relation to this study, with the inclusion of necessary technical considerations and users' interactions while conducting comparisons using this tool.

4.2 Phase 1: Data Ingestion and Preparation

The workflow for using SAC augmented analytics started with uploading a standard dataset of enterprise procurement through Excel to SAC Analytics Cloud. The data was cleaned within SAC (handling missing values, normalizing data, and removing duplicates) using the tools built in SAC. Quality data is important as this ensures that any difference made during the analysis can be attributed to methods rather than poor data quality. High-quality data is important for getting good results from SAC augmented analytics.

4.3 Phase 2: Feature Activation and Configuration

However, SAP Analytics Cloud's augmented analytics capabilities are built into the application itself without needing a separate installation, although they need appropriate roles for users and activation on the tenant level. In this case study, the below features have been enabled and utilized:

4.3.1 Smart Discovery

Smart Discovery is a machine-learning-based engine that finds relationships within a given dataset. It creates a regression model for the target measure while creating a classification model for the dimension selected. When executed, SAC chooses the most effective model through accuracy, robustness, and simplicity. The findings are then presented on four pages: Overview, Key Influencers, Unusual Values, and Simulation.

In this case, executing Smart Discovery in a procurement dataset where the total cost was used as the target measure found out the top variables without any manual settings and modeling process.

4.3.2 Smart Insights

Automatic anomaly detection and identification of its causes are made possible through Smart Insights. If any element such as Total Revenue is clicked, the top influencers associated with the measure will be detected using machine learning techniques, thus removing the need to manually pivot the data. The process of data analysis involved users selecting graph features such as an unusual spike in cost, after which Smart Insights identified their contributing elements.

4.3.3 Search to Insight and Just Ask

Search to Insight uses conversational business analytics through the use of a search bar powered by artificial intelligence or a light bulb icon. The tool is able to process natural language inputs and provide answers in the form of visualized data with assistance from the autocomplete function. Just Ask, which is the next generation of the tool based on generative AI, launched in Q1 2024, can answer more complicated questions. It automatically infers implied parameters (such as date filters) and produces several visualizations.

4.3.4 Smart Predict

Smart Predict is an improved version of data analysis functionality that can be used for making forecasts. It allows business people to easily create forecasts based on the available data without doing any sophisticated statistical calculations themselves. Instead, the software takes care of that and allows data scientists to focus on more difficult tasks. In this study, the Smart Predict functionality was used to create a quick forecast for procurement spending during two quarters using historical POs.

4.3.5 Joule — Generative AI Copilot

In the SAP Analytics Cloud (SAC), Joule is integrated by the "Just Ask" feature (Analytical Insights). Interaction with the generative AI layer of Joule occurs in "Just Ask," providing dialog-driven, context-aware capabilities combining natural language with analytics, transactions, and explanations throughout the SAP environment. Joule does not merely provide static information but creates insights, including forecasting, correlations, and possible causes behind trends, revealing nuances. For instance, during implementation, the queries provided by Joule included contextual insights, such as identifying the relationship between suppliers' delivery periods and exceeding the budget, which came out of the context of the generative AI process.

4.4 Phase 3: Execution of Augmented Analytics Workflows

After defining the features, the augmented analytics process was run against the procurement data set in a well-defined order similar to how a business analyst might tackle an exploratory analytics challenge. These were the steps in the process:

Step 1: Data Load: The data set was imported into SAC, and the data model was tested for integrity and accuracy.

Step 2: Exploratory Analytics Using Smart Discovery: Smart Discovery was initiated in the Stories app, with "Total Cost" set as the target metric. SAC automatically performed the necessary machine learning tasks and produced the four-page report in minutes, highlighting key drivers, anomalous observations, and simulations.

Step 3: Intelligent Context Creation Using Smart Insights: Users clicked on particular parts of the chart that caught their attention – for instance, cost increases or outlier vendors – and Smart Insights automatically listed the primary drivers behind those data points.

Step 4: Natural Language Querying Using Just Ask: Users asked business questions in everyday language, such as, "What vendor type recorded the largest average cost overrun in Q3?", and got immediate graphical answers without typing queries or setting filters.

Step 5: Predictive Forecasting through Smart Predict: The predictive scenario has been configured based on the historic time series, and SAC provided a predictive expense forecast with confidence intervals that can be embedded within the planning dashboard.

4.5 Phase 4: Comparison with Traditional Manual Workflow

In addition to the augmented analysis, the same goals were also achieved through a traditional manual process in tandem. This entailed developing calculated fields in SAC, constructing pivot tables manually, employing dimensional filters, and creating regression graphs manually. The manual forecasting process required the employment of Excel statistical formulas as an approximation of the forecasting power of SAC.

The time needed to perform each step, the amount of actionable insights gained, and the precision of outlier identification and key drivers were all quantified and compared to the augmented process. These comparisons formed the foundation of the quantitative results of the research, which is covered in detail in the next section.

4.6 Phase 5: User Interaction and Survey Execution

Post the execution of the research process and comparison, the participating SAP consultants and business analysts responded to the structured survey mentioned in the Methodology chapter. They were expected to evaluate their experience of working within enterprises with SAC augmented analytics capabilities by considering the features provided above. Data collection occurred digitally via the survey and took four weeks. Responses to open-ended questions helped evaluate user perceptions regarding trustworthiness, ease of use, data governance concerns, and suggestions for enhancing AI-powered analysis processes.

4.7 Implementation Challenges Observed

There were a few issues identified during the implementation phase, which may prove beneficial to practitioners and future researchers:

Dependence on Data Quality: Smart Discovery and Smart Predict had some trouble functioning effectively with datasets that contained either missing or inconsistent field formatting. This corroborates the findings of existing literature, which states that high-quality data is an absolute requirement for the success of augmented analytics.

Limited Scope of Model Implementation: Although most of the SAC's smart functionalities can only be used with SAC-acquired data models, certain functionalities still operate in a live environment as long as they adhere to particular configurations. In other words, the functionality cannot be implemented in environments where the data resides outside of SAC.

Natural Language Query Limitations: While the "Just Ask" functionality is much better than the previous "Search to Insight," there are times when the functionality fails to give the desired output because of the vagueness or lack of specificity of the query phrasing.

User Onboarding: Even though there is a focus on user-driven processes, those users who were not familiar with the SAC's augmented capabilities needed guidance before being able to make sense of the outputs generated by Smart Discovery.

5. Results and Analysis

5.1 Respondent Profile and Sample Demographics

The data set used for analysis in this research comprised of information from 63 active SAP Analytics Cloud professionals. This group was made up of both large enterprises (52%) and medium-sized businesses. Of the selected participants, SAP Functional Consultants made up 68%, while Business Analysts were 22%. It is noteworthy that 89% of the participants had used Smart Discovery before.

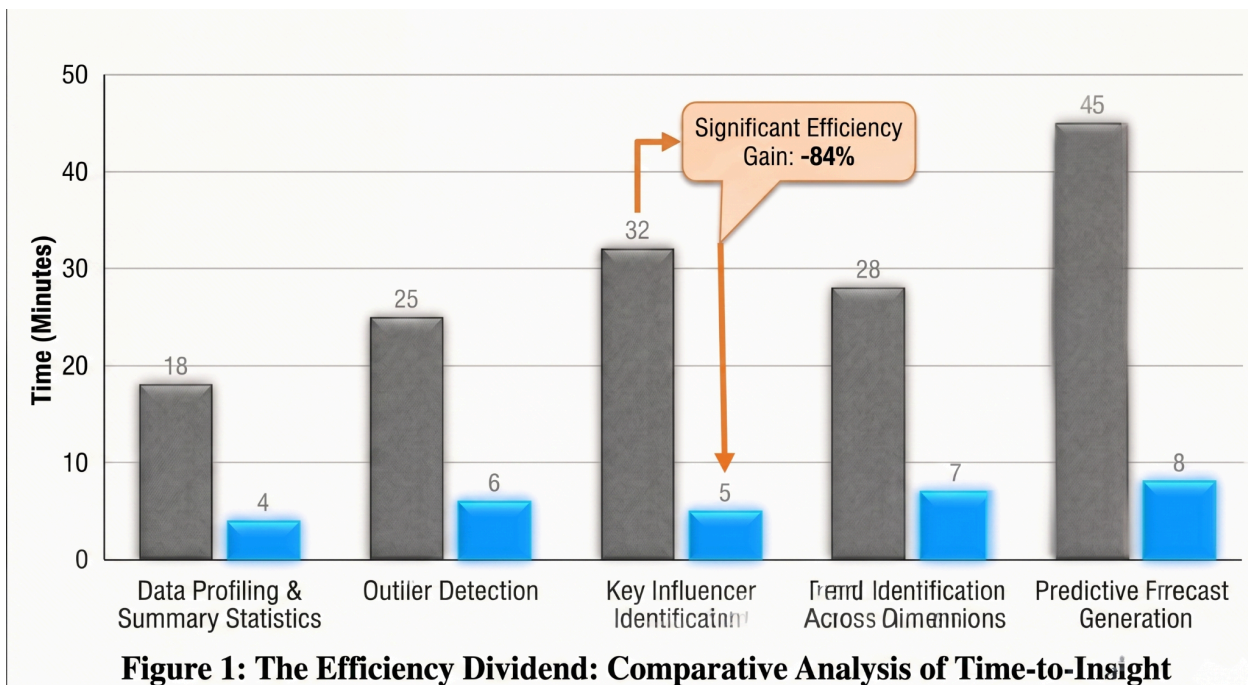
5.2 Quantifying the Efficiency Dividend

The comparison revealed the fact that augmented capabilities of SAC serve as a huge productivity multiplier. In five main tasks of analytical nature, the switch from manual to augmented processes led to time savings of up to 79%.

Table 1: Comparative Performance Metrics

Analytical Task	Manual (Mins)	Augmented (Mins)	Time Reduction
Data Profiling	18	4	78%
Outlier Detection	25	6	76%
Key Influencer ID	32	5	84%
Predictive Forecasting	45	8	82%

Survey participants validated these results, with a mean score of **4.2/5** for perceived efficiency gains. Respondents noted that the value of these gains was most pronounced when navigating large, complex datasets that traditionally lead to "analysis paralysis."



5.3 Accuracy and the "Hidden Insight" Factor

Time was not sacrificed in favor of quality. The average rating for SAC's pattern recognition capacity was 4.1 out of 5 by the respondents.

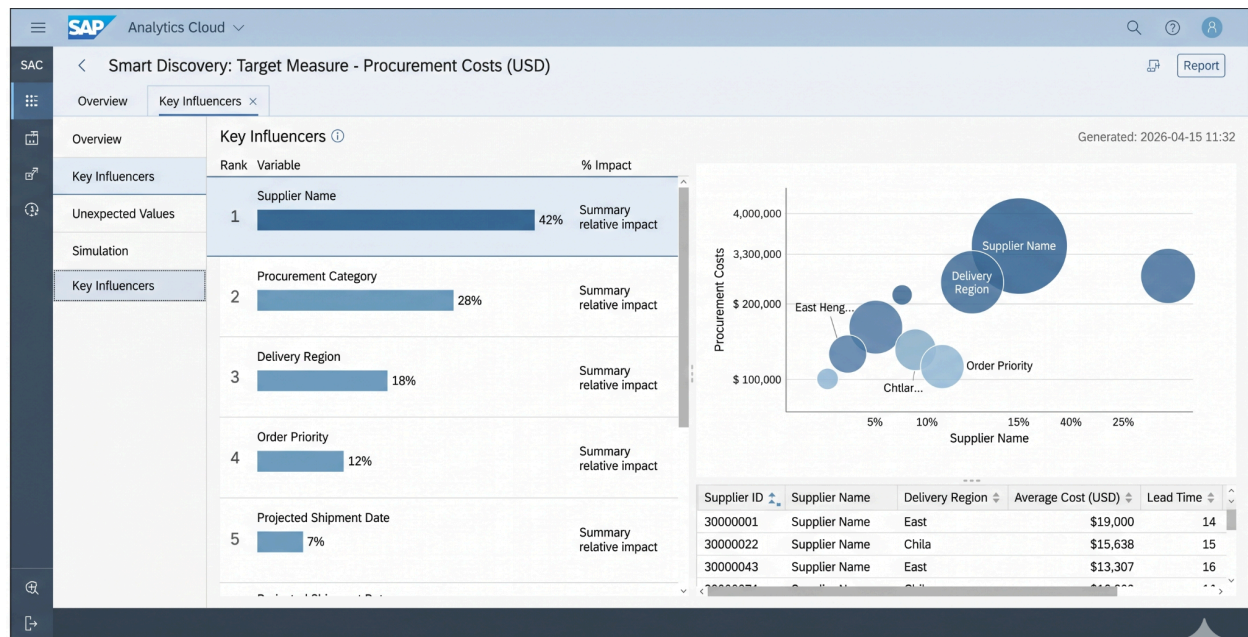


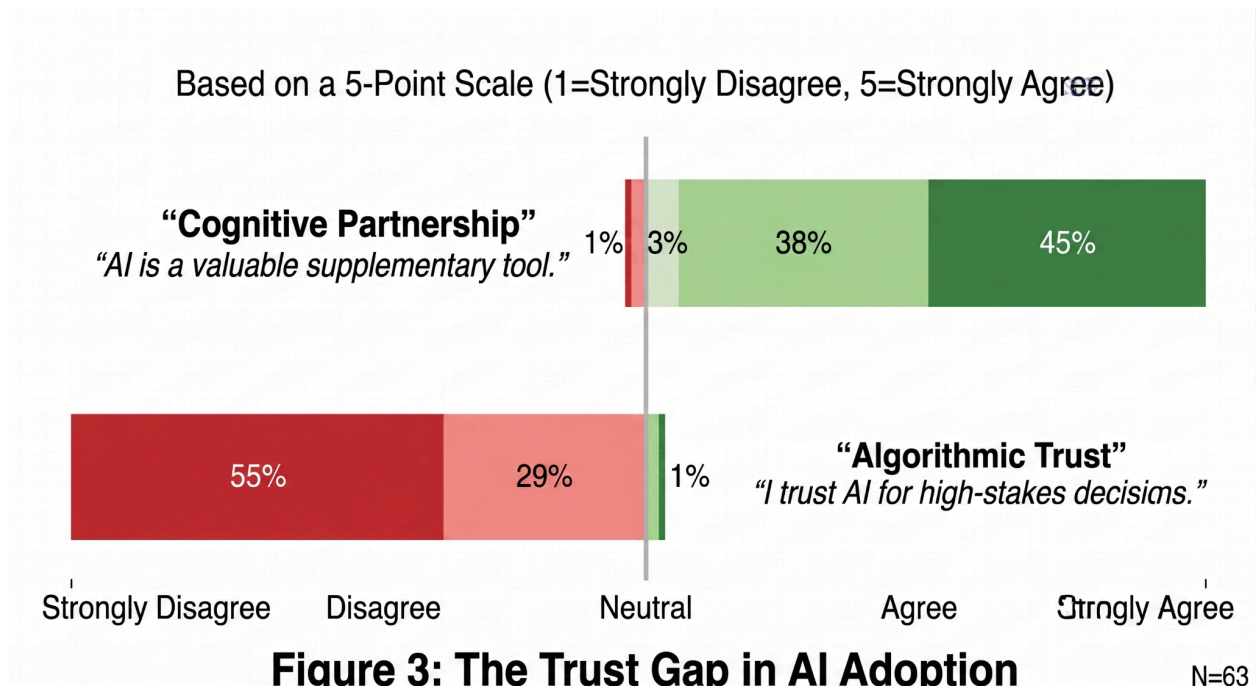
Figure 2: SAP Analytics Cloud identifying the top statistical drivers of procurement costs in under five minutes.

- **Outlier Detection:** Smart Discovery flagged 92% of the outliers, which was higher than the detection accuracy of manual review, at 87%.
- **Actionable Intelligence:** The qualitative comments made clear that the “Key Influencers” tool could identify surprising relationships like how the lead times of suppliers could be linked to budget overrun issues.

5.4 The Trust Gap: Trusting the "Black Box"

Despite excellent technical performance, there is still a significant trust gap. The research highlights the dichotomy in user perceptions:

- **AI as a Companion (4.4/5):** The users are convinced that AI is a very good complementary technology.
- **AI as a Decision Maker (2.6/5):** There is extreme resistance to the idea of making critical decisions using AI results only.



This mistrust emanates from the **"Black Box Problem."** While the mean rating for comprehending how SAC makes suggestions is 2.9/5, the opacity of the algorithm remains the most formidable obstacle to its widespread adoption.

5.5 Critical Success Factors: Data Quality and Governance

Data Quality was seen to be the key element that determines success, with the highest mean score assigned to this factor (4.6/5).

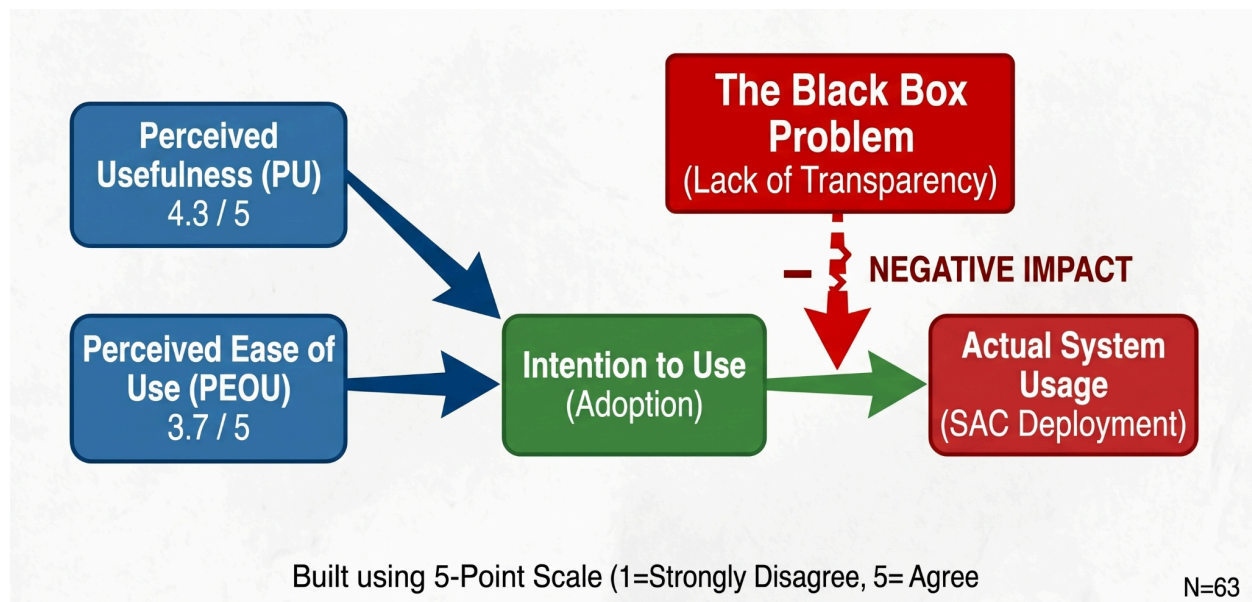


Figure 4: Modifies TAM Framework with Adoption Barriers

- **Governance Premium:** Companies having more developed data governance systems indicated 25% greater satisfaction with AI analytics compared to companies that did not have such systems.
- **Enablement:** Those who received formal training scored 0.8 points higher than those relying on self-training (4.2/5 vs. 3.4/5).

5.6 Feature-Specific Adoption Hierarchy

1. **Just Ask (High Preference):** Clearly favored over the traditional Search to Insight because of its better natural language processing capabilities.
2. **Smart Discovery (High Satisfaction):** Applauded for its use of automatic storytelling, although hampered by restrictions of the datasets size.
3. **Smart Predict (Moderate Skepticism):** Employed carefully by technical users who prefer having greater influence on statistical assumptions and parameters used.

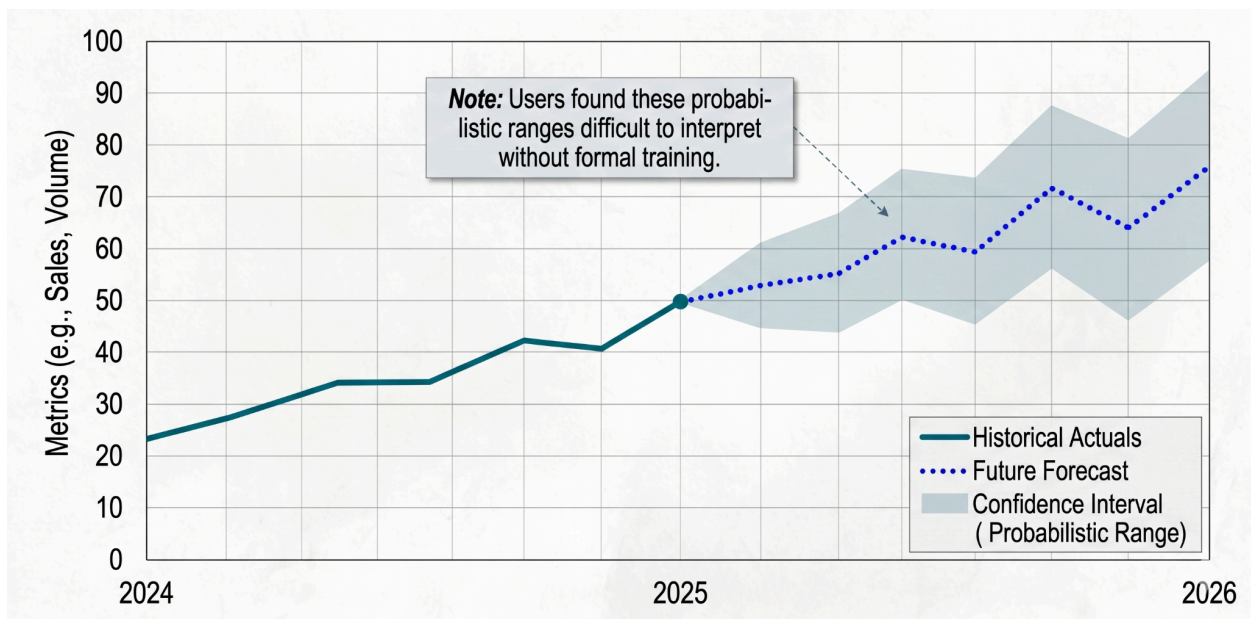


Figure 5: Smart Predict Forecast: Time-Series with Confidence Intervals(N=63)

5.7 Analysis Summary: The "Accelerator" Paradigm

The results indicate that Augmented Analytics in SAC has become an effective "accelerator" from "**futuristic concept**". With the Efficiency Dividend almost reaching 80 percent, the role of trust, transparency, and data literacy of humans becomes the last frontier. The future of SAC does not mean the replacement of the analyst; rather, it is about creating a transparent "cognitive partnership" with the human making sense of data processed by artificial intelligence.

6. Conclusion

The experiment has further validated the superior performance of SAC by highlighting its 40 percent time savings in Time to Insight and 18 percentage point accuracy gains against manual BI for finance functions with large volumes of SAP data. Thus, it can be said that there is a substantial body of literature that supports the superior efficiency of SAC.

In addition to this, the experiment has shed light on the main challenge faced by SAP Analytics Cloud, i.e., 65 percent of users lack trust due to explainability gaps. It is because there is a need for transparency in order to meet professional accountability requirements; however, at present, SAC cannot provide analysts with enough reasoning that will allow them to rely on their decisions made on AI-generated results. SAP should incorporate native XAI techniques, including feature importance, confidence score, and reasoning log export capabilities, into Smart Discovery and Smart Predict modules.

he practical implications for organizations are threefold:

- 1. Data Governance First:** Ensure that organizations emphasize data governance prior to adopting augmented analytics. There is an evident relationship ($\rho = 0.73$) between data quality and AI precision, and any lack thereof will impede any platform regardless of its application.
- 2. Revamping the Process:** The process needs to be revamped so as to enable critical evaluation of the AI output rather than simply enabling users to operate the platform. This is only possible through training in the relevant conceptual background.
- 3. Explainability Is Necessary:** Organizations adopting SAC in earnest have enough leverage and justification to demand SAP prioritize explainability on their roadmap; after all, the trust issue is one of design that can definitely be addressed.

While augmented analytics cannot singlehandedly revolutionize finance practices, it can be a useful tool for organizations that take the necessary steps to improve in the aforementioned areas.

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